We've reached 436 for one, with one over left.

Russell is bowling and Hash drives a single off the first delivery. I swing the bat at the second, slicing the ball into the outfield. We run two. Russell moves to bowl around the wicket, firing the ball across me. I ought to respond, to take account of the new line and shift my stance to the off side, but I don't. Maybe I'm getting tired. I swing at the third ball, and miss completely. It's a dot. The fourth delivery is a half-volley outside off. I try to drive it above cover point but my timing is not great and Jonathan Carter takes a comfortable catch on the boundary.

I'm out, and there's a hush around the stadium. Then the noise resumes as I walk briskly towards the dressing room. I never feel comfortable in the limelight, the centre of attention, and I'm eager to reach the sanctuary of the dressing room, hoping the guys can finish the innings well.

I sit down in my place, and take a deep breath.

Did that just happen?

Did that really happen?

As the adrenalin subsides, I feel exhilarated and amazingly blessed.

Our innings ends at 439 for two in 50 overs. In response, the West Indians score a respectable 291 for seven, but never threaten to overhaul our total. We take a 2–0 lead in the five-match series.

It was an extraordinary day. But what *really* mattered?

It really mattered that the Proteas played well as a team; that we played cricket to excite people both at the Wanderers and watching on television, inspiring them to follow, enjoy and play the game. It really mattered that we delivered a performance to help persuade our supporters, and perhaps ourselves, that, as a squad, we really do have the ability to perform well at the imminent 2015 Cricket World Cup, and maybe even win it. For me, personally, it mattered that I had tried my best and made people proud.

The records and the statistics genuinely don't matter at all. They are flashed across the television screen during the broadcast or printed in